THE WHOLE STORY · SMALL GROUP GUIDE · WEEK 36 OF 52

The Last Prophet and the Silent Years

Nehemiah 13 · Malachi 1–4 · Daniel 9:24 · Luke 2:25–32

The big idea: The revival faded, and Malachi, the last prophet of the Old Testament, called the people back: "Return to me, and I will return to you." Then came four hundred silent years, while God set the stage. In the fullness of time he sent his Son.

Before you meet: Read

Malachi 1:6–8 | Malachi 3:1–7 | Malachi 4:2–6 | Luke 2:25–32

Open (5 minutes)

Have you ever waited a long time for God to answer? What kept you going?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Return to me, and I will _____ to you, says the LORD of hosts." *(Malachi 3:7)*

"And the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his _____." *(Malachi 3:1)*

Discuss

1. The exiles came home to the land but kept drifting from God. Why is it possible to return outwardly without returning in your heart? *Malachi 1:6–8; 3:6–7*

2. God was silent for four hundred years but kept working. Where have you seen God at work when he seemed silent? *Galatians 4:4; Luke 2:25–32*

3. Malachi's people offered God their leftovers. Where are you tempted to give God what is left over? *Malachi 1:6–8*

Memory verse

> *"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law"*
>
> **Galatians 4:4**

Pray

Thank God that he keeps his promises, even after long silence. Ask him to turn your heart back to him, and thank him that the Father runs to meet everyone who comes home through Jesus.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 36

The Last Prophet and the Silent Years

Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Malachi 3:1–7 and Luke 2:25–32 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Luke 1–2 and John 1:1–18).

Main points to land

1. The people returned to the land without fully returning to God. Malachi called them back and promised the Lord would come to his temple (Malachi 3:1, 7).
2. The silent years were not empty. God was setting the stage, and faithful people like Simeon kept waiting for the consolation of Israel (Luke 2:25).
3. After four hundred silent years, God sent his Son in the fullness of time. Jesus is the greater glory of the temple (Galatians 4:4; Luke 2:27–32).

Core doctrine to teach

The Faithfulness of God CORE DOCTRINE 18 OF 26

God always keeps his word. He promised to bring his people home after seventy years, and he did. He promised to send a Messiah, and through four hundred silent years he did not forget. Every promise of God finds its yes in Jesus Christ.

Jeremiah 29:10; Lamentations 3:22–23; 2 Corinthians 1:20; 2 Timothy 2:13

Answer key (Observe)

1. return
2. temple

Questions people will ask

Why was God silent for four hundred years?

Scripture does not tell us all his reasons. It does show that he was still working: the world gained a common language, the Old Testament was translated into Greek, and Roman roads were built. Paul says God sent his Son when the fullness of time had come (Galatians 4:4). Silence is not absence.

Closing prayer

Father, you kept your promise to bring your people home, and you kept working through four hundred silent years. Turn our hearts back to you. Let your word be central among us, and let the joy of the LORD be our strength. Thank you for sending your Son in the fullness of time, the greater glory, the Lord who came to his temple. Amen.